



LANE COUNTY • BUYING YOUR HOME • FALL 2026

From first showing to *keys* in hand

Buying a home here is one of the biggest decisions you will make, and most of the stress comes from not knowing what happens next. This guide walks you through every step in order: the money, the search, the offer, the inspections, and closing day, with the Oregon details other guides leave out.



3.5%

MINIMUM DOWN PAYMENT ON AN
FHA LOAN

10

BUSINESS DAYS A BUYER
TYPICALLY HAS TO INSPECT

30-45

DAYS FROM ACCEPTED OFFER TO
CLOSING ON A TYPICAL LANE
COUNTY CONTRACT



01 · WELCOME

A home is more than a *house*

I believe in a home. It is where your life happens, and the place you choose says a lot about the life you want. That is exactly why buying one can feel overwhelming. It is a lot of money, a lot of paperwork, and a lot of decisions made on a deadline.

My job, with my team at The Operative Group behind me, is to take the heavy lifting off you. We will set a budget that fits your real life, find the right place, negotiate terms that protect you, and get you to a clean, calm closing. This booklet is the map. Keep it handy, write in it, and text me whenever a page raises a question.

Larissa Mayfield · The Operative Group · Real Broker





Eight steps, in the *order* they happen

1. **Talk money first.** A lender looks at your income, credit and savings and tells you what you can borrow. That number, and the monthly payment you are comfortable with, set the search.
2. **Sign a buyer agreement with me.** Oregon requires one in writing. It spells out what I do for you and how I am paid (page 05).
3. **Search and tour.** We narrow the field to homes worth your Saturday, then go see them.
4. **Write the offer.** Price, terms, dates and contingencies, built from what has actually sold nearby.
5. **Offer accepted.** Earnest money goes to the title company, and the clock starts on your contingency periods.
6. **Inspect and review.** Inspections, the seller's disclosure, and any well, septic or access questions. This is where most repair conversations happen.
7. **Appraisal and final loan approval.** The lender confirms the value and finishes underwriting.
8. **Walk through and close.** One last look, sign at the title company, and the keys are yours once the deed records.

Every step has a deadline written into your contract. I track every one of them so you never have to.

Text 541.784.7745 to start step one →



PART ONE

Before you *shop*

The money, the agreement, and the plan. Getting these right first is what makes the rest of the process calm.





Your broker works for *you*, and only you

When you hire me as your buyer's broker, I owe you real duties under Oregon law, not just good service. In plain English:

- **Loyalty.** Your interests come first. I do not represent the seller's side of your purchase.
- **Care.** I use my skill and knowledge to protect you, and I tell you what I see.
- **Confidentiality.** Your budget, your timeline and how much you love a house stay between us.
- **Disclosure.** I tell you what I know that matters to your decision.
- **Accounting.** Your earnest money and documents are handled correctly and on time.

Before we work together you will get Oregon's initial agency disclosure pamphlet, which explains these relationships in the state's own words.

STAGE

WHAT I AM DOING FOR YOU

Searching

Setting up a search that matches how you live, flagging homes before they hit the big sites, previewing when you cannot, pulling sold data

Writing the offer

Pricing it against real sales, choosing the terms that make it strong without exposing you, talking to the listing broker

Under contract

Tracking every deadline, scheduling inspections, negotiating repairs, keeping the lender and title company moving

Closing

Reviewing your closing statement with you, the final walkthrough, and handing you the keys



04 · THE BUYER AGREEMENT

What you sign, and *why*

Oregon now requires a written agreement between you and your buyer's broker. It is a short document, and it protects you as much as it does me. It covers:

- **What I will do** for you, and for how long the agreement runs.
- **Where you are looking**, or which property, if it is just one.
- **How I am paid**, and who pays it (next page).
- **How either of us can end it** if it is not working.

Read it before you sign it, and ask me anything. A good agreement has no surprises in it.

Ask me to walk you through it →

05 · HOW I AM PAID

No *mystery* about money

Since August 2024, broker pay is no longer advertised on the MLS. Instead, you and I agree in writing, up front, what I am paid. Then, on each home, we find out what the seller is willing to contribute.

- **Often the seller pays.** Many sellers still offer to cover the buyer's broker, and we can ask for it in the offer.
- **Sometimes it is part of the negotiation.** If a seller offers less, or nothing, we decide together how to handle the difference, whether that is asking for a concession or adjusting the offer.
- **You always know before you sign.** Nothing is ever taken out of your pocket that you did not agree to in writing.



The costs to plan for, *beyond* the price

The price of the home is the big number, but it is not the only one. Plan for all of these:

COST	WHEN	WHAT TO EXPECT
Earnest money	Within a few days of acceptance	Commonly around 1% of the price. It goes to the title company and is credited back to you at closing
Inspections	During the inspection period	A few hundred dollars for the home, more for well, septic, sewer scope or specialty inspections
Appraisal	After inspections, ordered by your lender	Usually paid up front or at closing, depending on the lender
Down payment	At closing	From 0% to 20% or more, depending on the loan
Closing costs	At closing	Lender fees, escrow, recording, your share of title costs, and prepaid taxes and insurance. Your lender gives you a Loan Estimate with real figures
Moving and setup	After closing	Movers, utilities, deposits, and the things a new house always needs

Oregon property tax works differently. Your tax is based on the property's assessed value, not its market value, and Oregon limits how fast assessed value can grow, usually to 3% a year. Bills go out in October, and paying the full year by November 15 earns a 3% discount. Your lender will usually collect taxes and insurance monthly with your payment.

A budget is a monthly payment you can live with, not the biggest loan a bank will give you.

Let's run your real numbers →



Know your number *before* you fall in love

A pre-qualification is a quick estimate. A pre-approval means a lender has actually checked your income, credit and assets, and it is what makes a seller take your offer seriously. Have this ready:

- **Income:** your last two years of W-2s or tax returns, and your most recent pay stubs (self-employed buyers: two years of business returns and a year-to-date profit and loss)
- **Assets:** the last two months of bank and retirement statements, and where your down payment is coming from
- **Identity:** a photo ID, and permission to pull your credit
- **Anything unusual:** gift funds, a divorce decree, child support, a recent job change. Tell the lender early; surprises late are what delay closings

Five questions to ask any lender

1. What will my monthly payment be, with taxes and insurance included?
2. How much cash will I need at closing, all in?
3. Which loan programs do I qualify for, and why would you choose one over another?
4. What rate can you lock, for how long, and what does it cost?
5. How quickly can you close, and who do I call when something comes up?



The loans most Lane County *buyers* use

LOAN	MINIMUM DOWN	GOOD TO KNOW
Conventional	3% for many first-time buyers, 5% otherwise	Mortgage insurance when you put down less than 20%, and it can come off later
FHA	3.5% with a 580+ credit score	Easier credit standards. Upfront and monthly mortgage insurance
VA	0% for eligible veterans and service members	No monthly mortgage insurance. A funding fee applies unless you are exempt
USDA	0%	For homes in eligible rural areas and buyers under the income limits. Much of rural Lane County qualifies, so check the address
Oregon Bond loan	Low down payment, with help available	From Oregon Housing and Community Services, for first-time buyers (or anyone who has not owned in three years) under income and price limits
FHA 203(k)	3.5%	One loan for the purchase and the repairs, for a house that needs work

Rules, fees and limits change. Treat this table as a starting point, and let a lender confirm what fits you.



When to *start*, and how long it takes

- **Two to three months before you want to move**, talk to a lender and get pre-approved. It gives you time to fix anything on your credit.
- **The search** can take a weekend or a season, depending on what you need and how many homes fit.
- **From accepted offer to keys** is usually 30 to 45 days, mostly set by your loan.
- **If you are renting**, check your lease's notice period now, so you are not paying two places for long.
- **If you need to sell first**, we can write your offer contingent on your sale. It is a weaker offer in a busy market, so we plan the timing together.





PART TWO

Finding it, and making it *yours*

The search, the showings, and an offer that is strong without leaving you exposed.





Touring *smart*

- **Tell me how you live**, not just bedrooms and baths. The commute, the shop, the animals, the garden, the quiet. I will set up a search that catches the right homes the minute they list.
- **Call me before you call the number on the sign**. If you visit a listing or an open house on your own, let them know you are working with me.
- **Builders are their own world**. Most new-construction builders want your broker registered at or before your first visit, or they may not let me represent you on that home. Text me before you walk into a model.
- **See it twice**. A second showing, at a different time of day, catches what the first one missed.
- **Look past the paint**. Furniture and wall colours are easy. Roof age, drainage, water, heat and access are not.



Strong is more than *price*

A seller weighs the whole offer, not just the number. Here is what we shape together:

- **Price**, from what has actually sold nearby, not what is still sitting unsold.
- **Earnest money**, the deposit that shows you are serious.
- **Financing**, and how much you are putting down.
- **Contingencies**, the conditions that let you walk away if something is wrong: inspection, financing, appraisal, and a sale of your current home if you need one.
- **Dates**, for closing and for possession, the day you get the keys.
- **Anything else that matters**: what stays with the house, credits toward closing costs, or a quick response deadline.

If other buyers want the same home, we talk through your options, like a cleaner offer, a shorter inspection period, or an escalation clause, and what each one actually risks.

I will never ask you to waive a protection without telling you exactly what it costs you if something goes wrong.

Talk through an offer →



PART THREE

Under contract, to *keys*

The weeks between yes and closing day. This is where a good broker earns their keep.





What happens the *first* week

Once the seller signs, the contract goes to the title company, a neutral party that holds the money and gathers every document needed to close.

1. **Earnest money.** You deliver it to the title company, usually within a few business days. It is credited toward your purchase at closing. Once your contingencies are satisfied, it is at risk if you walk away without a reason the contract allows.
2. **The seller's disclosure.** Oregon sellers give buyers a property disclosure statement. You have five business days after you receive it to revoke your offer, unless you waived that right. Read it carefully, and we will go through it together.
3. **Inspections get booked.** The inspection period starts now, so we schedule right away.



Your time to look *closely*

The inspection period, often 10 business days, is your chance to learn everything about the house before you are committed. I strongly recommend a full home inspection by a licensed inspector, every time.

1. **Schedule** the home inspection, plus anything the property calls for: sewer scope, radon, roof, pest, well and septic.
2. **Attend** if you can. Hearing the inspector explain something teaches you more than any report.
3. **Read the report** with me, and sort what is serious from what is normal wear.
4. **Decide:** ask for repairs, a credit or a price change, accept the house as it is, or walk away within your contract's terms.
5. **Agree in writing** with the seller before the period ends.

No house is perfect, including new ones. The point is to know what you are buying, and to price the problems in.

Ask what to inspect →



Wells, septic and *access*

Out here, the most important parts of a property are often the ones you cannot see from the driveway.

- **The well.** Oregon requires the seller to test a domestic well at sale for arsenic, nitrates and total coliform bacteria. Separately, we can order a flow test to make sure the well produces enough water, and an inspection of the pump, pressure tank and well head. The state keeps a well log for most wells, which tells us depth and how it was built.
- **The septic system.** A certified inspection, often with pumping, tells you its condition and size. County records show what was permitted, and how many bedrooms the system was approved for.
- **Access and easements.** Is the road public, private or shared, and who maintains it? A title report and a road maintenance agreement answer that.
- **Zoning and land use.** If you plan to build, add a dwelling, keep animals or run a business, we check what the zoning allows before you are committed.

If an inspection turns up a problem, the seller may repair it or offer a credit, or you may be able to end the contract within its terms.





15 · TITLE, INSURANCE AND WARRANTY

The *quiet* protections

- **Title.** The title company searches the public record for liens, easements and anything else attached to the property, and you review the preliminary title report. Title insurance protects your ownership from problems that were missed. In Oregon the seller usually pays for the owner's policy, and your lender requires a separate lender's policy.
- **Homeowner's insurance.** Your lender needs proof of coverage before closing. Shop it early, especially for rural, wooded or older homes, where quotes vary a lot.
- **Home warranty.** An optional service contract that helps with repairs to systems and appliances in the first year. Sometimes a seller will pay for one as part of the deal.

16 · THE APPRAISAL

When the value comes *back*

Your lender orders an appraisal to confirm the home is worth what you are paying. There are three ways it can come back:

THE APPRAISAL IS

WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS

At or above the price

Your loan moves forward. Nothing changes

Below the price

We can ask the seller to lower the price, you can cover the difference in cash, we can meet in the middle, or we can challenge the value with better comparable sales

Well below, with no agreement

If your contract has an appraisal or financing contingency, you may be able to end the contract and keep your earnest money



The walkthrough, and the *keys*

- **Final walkthrough.** A day or two before closing, we visit the house to confirm it is in the condition you agreed to, that agreed repairs are done, and that everything that should stay, has.
- **Your closing statement.** You will get it a few days ahead. We go through it line by line, so there are no surprises at the table.
- **Wiring money.** Call the title company at a number you already know before you send a cent. Never trust wiring instructions that arrive by email or text, even if they look real.
- **Signing.** You sign at the title company, usually a day or two before the official closing date.
- **Recording.** Closing happens when the deed records with the county and the money moves. Then the keys are yours, on the possession date in your contract.

Wire fraud is real and it targets buyers at the very end. If instructions ever change, stop and call me.

Save my number: 541.784.7745 →



In their words

Relocating my family member from another city was an overwhelming prospect. Thankfully we found Larissa and she made this all possible. From selling the first house to buying the second, she gave us countless hours of actual practical advice.

The Garneau family

We bought a house using Larissa as our real estate agent. From the beginning to the end of the process, Larissa was always knowledgeable and responsive. She took the extra steps and seamlessly took care of the details. She was also masterful at negotiations. ***The Hart family***

Larissa was great to work with on the purchase of our home, very knowledgeable and helpful. The buyer of our old home threw us a couple of curves, and she handled it all perfectly. We were out of town buyers and she helped a lot. ***The Clason family***

Larissa was amazing, so easy to work with and extremely responsive to anything we needed. We will definitely be using her again when we need a realtor, and telling our friends to use her as well. ***The Johnson family***



What *home* means to you

Fill this in before we start. It is the most useful thing you can bring to our first conversation.

Must have

Would love

Deal breakers

Areas I want to be in

Commute, or where I drive most

Land, shop, animals or garden

Monthly payment I'm comfortable with

When I want to move



Your first *three* steps

1. **Talk to a lender** and get pre-approved, so you know your number.
2. **Fill in your wishlist** on the last page.
3. **Text me.** We will sit down for half an hour, go through your wishlist and your budget, and I will set up a search that finds the right homes the minute they list.

There is no pressure and no obligation in that first conversation. Just questions, answered honestly, so you can decide when you are ready.

Text 541.784.7745, or find me at larissamayfieldre.com. I work with The Operative Group at Real Broker, LLC, so there is a whole team behind your purchase, and one person, me, who answers your texts.